

Topical Authority and Clusters

Depth on one topic beats shallow coverage of four, and there is now direct evidence that concentration is measured.

Bottom line

Topical authority means being demonstrably the site that covers a subject thoroughly. The 2024 API leak surfaced an attribute called `siteFocusScore`, which is the strongest available evidence that topic concentration is measured directly. Build the pillar-and-cluster structure from your Section 8 map, and finish one cluster before starting another.

What topical authority actually is

Not a metric you can look up. It is the outcome of covering a subject so completely that a search engine has no reason to send someone elsewhere for the adjacent question.

Three things make it work:

Coverage. You answer the whole family of questions around a topic, not one of them.

Interlinking. Those pages reference each other, which makes the relationship explicit rather than leaving it to be inferred.

Consistency. You keep publishing in that area rather than scattering across unrelated subjects.

The evidence

`siteFocusScore`, from the 2024 API leak, corroborates that Google measures how concentrated a site is on a topic. Attribute names are not weights and presence does not prove use in ranking, but it lines up with what practitioners had inferred for years. [practitioner]

AI retrieval rewards it more sharply than Google does. Sites with **5 or more interconnected pages** on a topic are reported **3.2x more likely to be cited** by AI platforms. Sites with **80%+ topical coverage retain 85.4% of AI visibility** despite query fan-out variation. [practitioner]

That second number is the strategic one. Because AI engines fan a prompt into 5 to 20 sub-queries, a single page can only match a few of them. Broad coverage across a topic is what survives the fan-out.

Clustered content is reported to generate 30 to 43% more traffic than standalone posts. Single vendor, treat the multiplier as directional. [practitioner]

The pillar and cluster structure

A **pillar page**, comprehensive, typically **2,500 to 4,000 words**, covering the whole topic broadly. It answers the head query and gives an orientation to everything underneath.

8 to 15 cluster pages, each going deep on one sub-intent that the pillar only summarizes.

Bidirectional internal links. The pillar links down to every cluster page. Every cluster page links back up to the pillar. Reported to raise AI citation probability **2.7x**. [practitioner]

Cluster pages may also link sideways to each other where genuinely relevant. Do not force it.

How to choose the topic

You cannot build authority on everything at once, and trying is the most common failure.

Choose the topic where:

- **You have genuine expertise or first-hand experience.** Section 14 explains why this is not optional.
- **The commercial value is highest.** From your Section 7 relevance scoring.
- **You have some existing content** to build on rather than starting from zero.
- **The competition is not entirely large brands.** From your Section 7 manual difficulty read.

One topic. Finish it. Then choose the next.

Building it from the map

Your Section 8 keyword map already contains the structure. Turn it into a build plan:

- 1 Identify the head cluster** for your chosen topic. That becomes the pillar.
- 2 List every other cluster** in the same topic area. Those are your cluster pages.
- 3 Mark what exists**, what needs rewriting, and what needs creating.
- 4 Order by priority**, using your relevance x intent score.
- 5 Publish the pillar first if it does not exist**, so cluster pages have something to link up to. If the pillar exists but is weak, fix it first for the same reason.

The completeness test

A cluster is finished when someone who reads the whole thing has no obvious next question you have not answered.

Practical check: take your pillar, list every question a reasonably curious reader would ask after reading it, and see whether each has a home. The ones that do not are your remaining cluster pages.

Your People Also Ask harvest from Section 6 is the fastest source of these. So is asking an AI engine what sub-queries it would run on the topic, which is the inverse prompting technique from the same section.

Common failure modes

Starting four clusters, finishing none. The most common. Four half-built clusters produce less than one complete one, because incompleteness is the thing being penalized.

A pillar that is just a table of contents. If it only links out without saying anything, it is thin. The pillar has to be genuinely useful on its own.

Cluster pages that overlap. That is cannibalization, which Section 8 covered. Each cluster page owns exactly one sub-intent.

Publishing the clusters and never linking them. Bidirectional linking is not decoration, it is the mechanism that makes the structure legible.

Abandoning the topic after eight weeks. Consistency is one of the three inputs. Sporadic coverage of six topics reads as no authority in any of them.

Why this matters

this is the structural shift that separates sites that plateau from sites that compound. A single excellent page is a single excellent page. A complete cluster changes how the whole domain is evaluated, and it is the only defense against query fan-out that actually holds.

Do this now

- 1 **Choose one topic** using the four criteria above. Write down why you chose it.
- 2 **Open your Section 8 map** and pull every cluster belonging to that topic.
- 3 **Identify or plan the pillar.** Does it exist? Is it comprehensive enough at 2,500 to 4,000 words?
- 4 **List the 8 to 15 cluster pages.** Mark exists, needs work, or needs creating.
- 5 **Run the completeness test.** List the questions a reader would still have and check each has a home. Add cluster pages for any that do not.
- 6 **Map the internal links.** Pillar to every cluster, every cluster back to pillar. Write the list out, you will build it in Section 16.
- 7 **Order the work** by priority and put a realistic date on finishing the cluster.
- 8 **Publish or fix the pillar first.**

Capstone step

You have one topic chosen with a documented reason, a pillar identified or planned, 8 to 15 cluster pages listed with their status, a completeness check done, and a link map ready to build. This is the structure Section 16 wires together.

Key takeaways

- Topical authority is coverage plus interlinking plus consistency. `siteFocusScore` from the 2024 leak is the strongest evidence that concentration is measured directly.
- AI retrieval rewards it harder than Google does: 5+ interconnected pages on a topic is reported at 3.2x citation likelihood, and 80%+ coverage retains 85.4% of AI visibility through fan-out.
- Pillar of 2,500 to 4,000 words, 8 to 15 cluster pages, bidirectional links between them.
- Finish one cluster before starting another. Four half-built clusters produce less than one complete one, because incompleteness is the thing being penalized.